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Communication and Persuasion

*Central and Peripheral Routes
to Attitude Change*



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To Lynn and Barbara



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Contents

Preface	vii
1. The Elaboration Likelihood Model of Persuasion	1
Introduction	1
Postulates of the ELM	5
Postulate on Underlying Motivation	5
Postulate on Variations in Elaboration	6
Postulate on How Variables Affect Persuasion	16
Postulates on Relatively Objective and Relatively Biased Elaboration	19
Postulate on Elaboration Versus Peripheral Cues	20
Postulate on Consequences of Elaboration	21
Retrospective	23
2. Methodological Factors in the ELM	25
Introduction	25
Assessing Attitudes and Persuasion	25
Initial Attitude Changes	27
Attitude Change Over Time	29
Assessing the Basic Constructs in the ELM	30
Argument Quality	31
Peripheral Cues	33
Message Elaboration	35
Need for Cognition: Assessing Elaboration Likelihood via Individual Differences	47
Retrospective	54

xii	Contents
3. The Ability to Elaborate in a Relatively Objective Manner	61
Introduction	61
Factors Affecting the Ability to Elaborate Objectively	61
Effects of Distraction on Message Elaboration and Persuasion	61
Effects of Moderate Message Repetition on Message Elaboration and Persuasion	68
Effects of Recipient Posture on Message Elaboration and Persuasion	73
Other Variables Affecting Ability to Process Objectively	76
Retrospective	79
4. The Motivation to Elaborate in a Relatively Objective Manner	81
Introduction	81
Factors Affecting the Motivation to Elaborate Objectively	81
Effects of Personal Relevance on Message Elaboration and Persuasion	81
Effects of Personal Responsibility on Message Elaboration and Persuasion	90
Effects of Number of Message Sources on Message Elaboration and Persuasion	96
Effects of Need for Cognition on Message Elaboration and Persuasion	101
Retrospective	109
5. Biased Elaboration	111
Introduction	111
Ability Variables That Bias Elaboration: Focus on Prior Knowledge	111
Effects of Schemata on Processing One-Sided Messages	112
Effects of Schemata on Processing Two-Sided Messages	115
Motivational Variables That Bias Elaboration: Focus on Forewarning	115
Forewarning of Message Content	116
Forewarning of Persuasive Intent	126
Other Variables That Bias Message Elaboration	130
Bogus Personality Feedback	130
High Levels of Message Repetition	131

Contents	xiii
Hemispheric Asymmetry	134
Audience Expressions of Approval or Disapproval	136
Biased Processing or Peripheral Cues?	139
Retrospective	140
6. Message Elaboration Versus Peripheral Cues	141
Introduction	141
Objective Processing Versus Peripheral Cues	141
Personal Relevance and the Operation of Peripheral Cues	142
Additional Moderators of Cue Use: Distraction, Need for Cognition, and Others	158
Biased Processing Versus Peripheral Cues	165
Effects of Schemata on the Use of Peripheral Cues	165
Testing the ELM Analysis of Prior Knowledge	170
Retrospective	172
7. Consequences of the Route to Persuasion	173
Introduction	173
Persistence of Persuasion	173
Enhanced Thinking Produces Persistence	173
Testing the ELM Analysis of Persistence	175
Alternative Models of Attitude Persistence	178
Attitude-Behavior Link	185
Enhanced Thinking Produces Attitude-Behavior Consistency	185
Testing the ELM Analysis of Attitude-Behavior Consistency	187
Resistance to Counterpersuasion	190
Enhanced Thinking Produces Resistance	190
Testing the ELM Resistance Predictions	191
Retrospective	195
8. Intricacies of the Elaboration Likelihood Model	197
Introduction	197
Variables With Multiple Effects on Elaboration	198
Variables That Enhance and Reduce Message Processing	198
Shifting Processing From Objective to Biased	204
Variables That Affect Message Processing and Serve as Peripheral Cues	204
Multiple Effects of Source Expertise and Attractiveness	204
Other Variables With Multiple Effects	211

Processing When No Message or Both Sides Are Presented	215
Retrospective	216
9. Epilogue	217
Introduction	217
Determinants of Elaboration Likelihood	218
Integrative Potential of the ELM	221
Conclusions	223
References	225
Author Index	249
Subject Index	257

Chapter 1

The Elaboration Likelihood Model of Persuasion

Introduction

On New Year's Day, 1986, U.S. President Ronald Reagan and U.S.S.R. Premier Mikhail Gorbachev appeared on television in each other's countries. It was the first time that American and Russian leaders had exchanged messages that were simultaneously televised. Reagan's message, broadcast without warning during the popular Soviet evening news, spoke of world peace and called for the development of new defensive weapons. Gorbachev's message, which appeared while many Americans were watching coverage of the traditional Tournament of Roses parade, also spoke of peace but decried seeking security with new weaponry. How effective were these messages likely to be? What would be the major determinant of effectiveness—the substance of the messages, or the appearance and demeanor of the speakers? If the messages produced attitude changes, would these changes last and would they lead to changes in behavior?

Social psychologists have been concerned with questions such as these ever since the discipline began (Allport, 1935; Ross, 1908; see McGuire, 1985). The study of influence has also long been at the heart of many applied psychological fields such as consumer behavior (Bettman, 1986; Kassarian, 1982; Poffenberger, 1925; Strong, 1925) and clinical and counseling psychology (cf., Frank, 1963; Heppner & Dixon, 1981; Strong, 1968). Nevertheless, after a considerable flourishing of research and theory from the 1920s through the 1960s, interest in the psychology of persuasion began to wane. Two factors were largely responsible for this. First, the utility of the attitude construct itself was questioned as researchers wondered whether attitudes were capable of predicting behavior. Some reasoned that if attitudes did not influence behavior, then it might be time to abandon the attitude concept (Abelson, 1972; Wicker, 1971). Second, so much conflicting research and theory had developed that it had become clear that "after several decades of research, there (were) few simple and direct empirical